

Appendix for Prompt Optimization with Verifiable Rewards for Synthetic Essays in Automated Essay Scoring

Sungjin Nam¹[0000–0002–1893–4878]

ACT Education Corp., Iowa City IA 52243, USA
sungjin.nam@act.org

A LLM Prompts for Synthetic Essay Generation

A.1 Templates for Synthetic Essay Generation

Your input fields are:

1. 'target_score' (UnionType[int, str]): Target 'final score' for the simulated essay based on the rubric. Note that in some essay prompts, 'final score' is a total composite score of individual writing rubric traits with smaller point allocations (e.g., 1-4 for each trait, and 5-20 for the total score from the five traits). This can be a single integer point or a score range.
2. 'essay_prompt' (str): Prompt for the simulated essay.

Your output fields are:

1. 'starting_sentences' (dict[Literal['A', 'B', 'C', 'D', 'E'], str]): 5 starting sentences for the essay.
2. 'starting_sentence_pick' (str): Randomly pick one for the starting sentences. Return a single letter, without any formatting, from A to E.
3. 'generated_essay' (str): Write the essay with the selected starting sentence, without the index letter.

All interactions will be structured in the following way, with the appropriate values filled in.

```
[[ ## target_score ## ]]  
{target_score}
```

```
[[ ## essay_prompt ## ]]  
{essay_prompt}
```

```
[[ ## starting_sentences ## ]]  
{starting_sentences}          # note: the value you produce must adhere to  
the JSON schema: {"type": "object", "additionalProperties": {"type":  
  "string"}, "propertyNames": {"enum": ["A", "B", "C", "D", "E"]}}
```

```
[[ ## starting_sentence_pick ## ]]
```

```

{starting_sentence_pick}

[[ ## generated_essay ## ]]
{generated_essay}

[[ ## completed ## ]]
In adhering to this structure, your objective is:
{Optimized LLM Prompt}

[[ ## target_score ## ]]
{target score}

[[ ## essay_prompt ## ]]
{Essay set descriptions}
{Scoring rubric}

Respond with the corresponding output fields, starting with the field ‘[[
  ## starting_sentences ## ]]' (must be formatted as a valid Python
  dict[Literal['A', 'B', 'C', 'D', 'E'], str]), then ‘[[ ##
  starting_sentence_pick ## ]]', then ‘[[ ## generated_essay ## ]]',
  and then ending with the marker for ‘[[ ## completed ## ]]'.
```

A.2 Unoptimized Prompt Instructions

This instruction was used for the Base and Feature-Guided conditions.

```

You are an expert essay tutor. Simulate the student essays for a given
score level.
The essay does not need to start with the title.
Do not begin with: The, In, I, It, This, There, As, From, Since
Do not begin with a quotation or part of the writing prompt's title.
Do not use tool in any outputs. Follow the formatting instructions.
```

A.3 Automatically Optimized Instructions

This is an example instruction optimized for Essay Set 2, using word_count as the optimization target, with GPT-OSS-20B as the generator.

```

**Task: Generate a 10th-grade persuasive editorial on library censorship
**

You will receive a **single JSON-style object** containing the following
keys:

| Key                               | Description |
|-----|-----|
| **target_score**         | Integer 1-6 - the rubric score the essay must
  achieve. |
```

```

| **essay_prompt**          | Full prompt text (includes quotation and
|                           | rubric). |
| **related_stats**        | For each possible score (1-6) a *mean* and *
|                           | standard deviation* for 'word_count'. |
| **starting_sentences**   | Dictionary of five candidate opening
|                           | sentences labelled "A"-"E". |
| **starting_sentence_pick** | The key (e.g., "C") that tells you which
|                           | opening sentence to use. |

Your job is to **write ONE essay** that satisfies **all** constraints
below.
Output **only** the essay text (plain paragraphs). No titles, quotations,
JSON, headings, tool tags, or any explanatory metadata may appear.

---

### 1. Opening sentence
- The essay **must begin** with the exact sentence from '
  starting_sentences' whose key equals 'starting_sentence_pick'.
- There must be **no characters** (including spaces, line-breaks,
  invisible Unicode) before this sentence.
- If that sentence starts with any **prohibited first word** (case-
  insensitive): 'The', 'In', 'I', 'It', 'This', 'There', 'As', 'From',
  'Since', prepend a **neutral bridge** of **3-4 words** (e.g., "Indeed
  ," "Consider this," "Reflect on this") that **does not** itself start
  with a prohibited word. Keep the original opening sentence unchanged
  after the bridge.

### 2. Word-count window
1. Retrieve the 'mean' and 'std' for the given 'target_score' from '
  related_stats'.
2. Compute:
  'lower = mean - std'
  'upper = mean + std'
  (Treat these as real numbers; do **not** round.)
3. The final essay's total word count **must satisfy** 'lower\u202f<=\\
  u202fcount\u202f<=\\u202fupper' (inclusive).
  - Count words by splitting the final text on **whitespace**; every
  token separated by whitespace counts as one word.

### 3. Stylistic length expectations (use as a guide **in addition** to
the statistical window)
| Score | Approx. words | Typical features |
|-----|-----|-----|
| 1 | 50-120 | Very brief, simple/repetitive sentences, minimal
organization. |
| 2 | 130-250 | Short sentences, weak transitions, limited detail. |
| 3 | 250-400 | Clear intro/body/conclusion, some supporting details,
occasional complex sentences. |

```

4	400-550	Clear thesis, logical paragraph order, varied sentences, few lapses.
5	560-700	Strong cohesion, frequent complex sentences, precise vocabulary, minor slips.
6	700-1000	Sophisticated, nuanced argument, rich vocabulary, multiple rhetorical devices, flawless organization.

If the statistical window allows a length outside the range above, **still write** so that the essay *reads* like a genuine piece at the required score level (adjust detail, sentence complexity, etc.).

4. Content requirements

- **Topic:** Persuade a newspaper readership about **censorship in libraries**.
- **Position:** Clearly state **for or against** the removal of offensive material.
- **Arguments:** Provide **at least two distinct arguments**.
 - Each argument must be illustrated with a **personal experience, observation, or a specific reading/example**.
- **Conclusion:** End with a paragraph that restates your stance and offers a final thought or call-to-action.

5. Tone & voice

- Use a **formal-personal register** appropriate for a 10th-grade student.
- The sophistication of vocabulary, sentence structures, and rhetorical devices should match the **target_score** (simpler & direct for low scores, confident & nuanced for high scores).

6. Organization (recommended structure)

1. **Intro paragraph** - starts with the required opening sentence, immediately states your position.
2. **Body paragraphs** - 2-3 paragraphs, each presenting **one** argument plus its personal illustration. Use transitions appropriate to the score level (e.g., "First," "Second," "Moreover" for higher scores; simpler connectors for lower scores).
3. **Conclusion paragraph** - restate thesis, summarize key points, and finish with a memorable closing or call-to-action.

7. Draft-revise-polish workflow (follow **exactly**)

1. **Parse the input** - extract 'target_score', the chosen opening sentence, and its 'mean'/'std'.
2. **Calculate bounds** - compute 'lower' and 'upper'. Keep them in mind.
3. **Plan** - outline intro, each argument with personal example, and conclusion while considering the stylistic expectations for the score.
4. **Draft** - write full sentences, respecting the exact opening line (or adding the short bridge if needed). Include required arguments and examples.

```

5. **Count words** - split the draft on whitespace and count.
  - If the count is **outside** '[lower, upper]', **adjust organically**:
    * Add or expand a sentence that naturally deepens an argument, adds
      a relevant detail, or improves transition.
    * Remove or condense redundant wording only if it does not weaken
      required arguments or coherence.
  - Never insert filler text ("Lorem ipsum") or mechanically duplicate
    sentences.
6. **Polish** - verify:
  - Opening sentence is exact and first characters.
  - No prohibited word precedes it (bridge added only if necessary).
  - No title, quotation, or extra metadata is present.
  - Word count is within bounds.
  - Essay length and style match the target score.
  - All content requirements (position, >=2 arguments with personal
    examples, concluding paragraph) are met.
  - Sentence variety appropriate to the score, correct punctuation,
    capitalization, and overall fluency.
7. **Return** the final essay as plain text.

### 8. Common pitfalls to avoid
  - Adding any characters (even a space) before the required opening line.
  - Repeating the quotation from the prompt.
  - Exceeding the word-count window.
  - Omitting the required number of arguments or personal examples.
  - Using any of the prohibited first words **before** the opening sentence
    (the bridge, if needed, must also avoid them).
  - Including titles, headings, or any meta-information.
  - Making mechanical, non-organic changes to hit the word count.

By strictly adhering to the above procedure, the produced essay will
  satisfy every constraint and convincingly simulate a 10th-grade
  student's persuasive editorial. Good luck!"

```

B Synthetic Essay Examples

The following examples show synthetic essays generated with different LLMs and prompt conditions for Essay Set 2 using GPT-OSS-20B.

```

# Essay Set #2
Type of essay: Persuasive/ Narrative/Expository
Grade level: 10
Average length of essays: 350 words
Rubric score range: 1-6
Final score range: 1-6

# Prompt

```

Censorship in the Libraries

"All of us can think of a book that we hope none of our children or any other children have taken off the shelf. But if I have the right to remove that book from the shelf -- that work I abhor -- then you also have exactly the same right and so does everyone else. And then we have no books left on the shelf for any of us." --Katherine Paterson, Author

Write a persuasive essay to a newspaper reflecting your vies on censorship in libraries. Do you believe that certain materials, such as books, music, movies, magazines, etc., should be removed from the shelves if they are found offensive? Support your position with convincing arguments from your own experience, observations, and/or reading.

Rubric Guidelines

...

Base Prompt Score 1 Essay:

```
{
  "starting_sentences": {
    "A": "Apparently, the idea that books should be removed from
libraries seems unfair to me.",
    "B": "Clearly, teachers often think censorship keeps kids safe.",
    "C": "Possibly, my feelings about this topic are mixed.",
    "D": "Sometimes, people worry about the content in magazines.",
    "E": "Noticeably, some readers dislike seeing certain music in
schools."
  },
  "starting_sentence_pick": "C",
  "generated_essay": "Possibly, my feelings about this topic are mixed.
Clearly, many people think removing books is good. Also, many think
it restricts learning. Some schools remove books because of
complaints. However, these actions may hurt education. Parents often
ask for safer reading. Still, this limits choices. Some argue freedom
of books matters. To sum up, many think the debate continues."
}
```

Score 6 Essay:

```
{
  "starting_sentences": {
    "A": "Imagine a library where every book has been silenced by
anonymous hands.",
    "B": "Imagine a space where the shelves stand mute, each tome
locked behind unseen barriers.",
    "C": "Imagine walking into a hall where the musty silence
replaces the chatter of curious minds.",
    "D": "Imagine a sanctuary whose doors close on the stories many
are eager to read.",
  }
```

```

"E": "Imagine a world where every child\u2019s curiosity is
stifled by a curtain of censorship."
},
"starting_sentence_pick": "C",
"generated_essay": "Imagine walking into a hall where the musty
silence replaces the chatter of curious minds. Such a scenario forces
us to weigh the value of free access against the comfort of
censorship. Because knowledge thrives on questioning, restricting
literature stifles critical thinking. Reflecting on my visits to the
campus library, I have witnessed students confront challenging titles
with curiosity, not fear. However, opponents argue that offensive
material may distort young minds and hinder community harmony.
Graceful as children\u2019s wonder may appear, their developmental
stage demands exposure to diverse perspectives rather than imposed
silence. Until now, school boards have rarely tasked
themselves with curating shelves to match parental whispers. Every
instance of removal\u2014whether it involves 'The Absolutely True
Diary of a Part-Time Indian' or a controversial documentary\u2014
fuels resentment toward authority. Most educators prioritize a
curriculum that equips students with analysis skills, not with
compliance. Furthermore, research indicates that exposure to complex
narratives cultivates empathy, essential for democratic discourse.
Moreover, when students discover that their books have been tampered
with, they become curious about the reasons behind such actions,
igniting investigative conversations. Consequently, transparency and
dialogue prove more effective than
blanket censorship in nurturing informed citizenship. Students who
were once skeptical of contentious stories began engrossing
themselves in discussions about morality, context, and authorship.
When curriculum designers wield filters, they risk creating a narrow
worldview, ultimately limiting the library\u2019s purpose as a
gateway to knowledge. Observing small debates in tutoring sessions, I
recognize that questioning rights produces mature arguments, not
passive agreement. Adding another dimension, scholars argue that
censorship often benefits a minority\u2019s agenda at the expense of
a society\u2019s collective growth. Paradoxically, the very books
removed often catalyze protests that
broaden the community\u2019s engagement with the topic. Drawing from
real\u2014life cases such as the controversy over 'To Kill a
Mockingbird', these protests reinforced the value of preserving
literature, no matter the discomfort. Therefore, it follows that a
deliberate, reasoned approach that retains all texts while educating
users is preferable over arbitrary removal. Hence, libraries should
remain neutral custodians, preserving all voices rather than
selectively amplifying silence. Ultimately, the vitality of any
democratic society lies in confronting uncomfortable ideas, not in
fearing them. Let us empower our students to navigate literature
responsibly, equipping them with the tools to

```

```
discern, critique, and respect divergent viewpoints. So the call is
simple: keep the shelves full, confront the content, and\u2014after
all\u2014teach the art of critical thought."
}
```

Feature-Guided Prompt Score 1 Essay:

```
{
  "starting_sentences": {
    "A": "Seeing whether a library can hold every book is tricky.",
    "B": "Addressing censorship in libraries demands careful thought
.",
    "C": "Debating whose books stay on the shelf feels intense.",
    "D": "Listening to people who want books removed can be hard.",
    "E": "Choosing what books are safe for readers worries many."
  },
  "starting_sentence_pick": "C",
  "generated_essay": "Debating whose books stay on the shelf feels
intense. Some people say we should pull books that hurt feelings or
seem wrong. They think removal stops bad influences. However, many
other people, librarians included, believe every book matters. If we
keep every book, people can see and think about new ideas. When the
shelves are cleared, we also lose learning chances. For example, a
student once wanted to read about a controversial topic for a school
project, but the book was taken away. The student was upset that they
could not learn. Even if some people think a book is poor, putting
it somewhere else can let people decide for themselves. After this,
keeping books in libraries helps to explore many different thoughts."
}
```

Score 6 Essay:

```
{
  "starting_sentences": {
    "A": "Curbing access to contested literature does little more
than stifle intellectual growth.",
    "B": "When shelves empty themselves of daring titles, the very
doors meant for learning swing shut.",
    "C": "Removing books that challenge our beliefs is more a
concession to fear than a guardian of values.",
    "D": "Silencing dissenting voices shortens discourse in a society
hungry for knowledge.",
    "E": "Allowing anonymous whims to dictate what students read
undermines the very purpose of libraries."
  },
  "starting_sentence_pick": "C",
  "generated_essay": "Because librarians serve as guardians of
knowledge, they must resist pressure to remove books under vague
pretenses. Students who encounter diverse viewpoints acquire critical
thinking skills that cannot be cultivated in a homogenous collection
```


. Censorship undermines intellectual curiosity by presenting a curated narrative that echoes only the dominant voice in the room. Examples abound of titles that once sparked debate, later removed for fear of backlash, and in doing so, libraries sacrificed their role as forums for dialogue.\n\n

Legislative attempts to ban works often backfire, stoking public interest and prompting activists to seek the very books they tried to silence. Legislation that depends on subjective criteria\u2014\charless to children\u201d and \u201cmorally suitable\u201d\u2014produces a slippery slope where teachers and parents can censor any material that challenges their worldview. Rather than stifle learners, such measures forces them to seek alternatives outside formal scholastic contexts, resulting in uneven and precarious access to information.\n\n

Beyond politics, censorship strips readers of emotional resonance. Dystopian novels remind us that tyranny thrives on misinformation, while memoirs expose the lives of those marginalized by society. Access to these stories cultivates empathy\u2014a quality essential for democratic citizenship. Silencing these narratives deprives students of the chance to confront uncomfortable truths, thereby sanitizing history and denying them the ethical frameworks needed for informed decision-making.\n\n

Alternatives to removal include contextualizing content. Librarians can provide study guides, host discussions, and facilitate conversations that illuminate potentially challenging sections. Guided inquiry allows learners to frame objections in an academic setting rather than through suppression. When educators employ critical frameworks, students gain agency over their learning journey while still respecting community standards. Cultivating such practices encourages reflective stewardship rather than passive acceptance.\n\n

Religious groups, parents, or political campaigns frequently champion censorship as a defense of moral values. However, poor peer-reviewed research suggests that restricting literature correlates with lower educational achievement. Censorship does not protect children; it limits curiosity and fortifies ignorance. Encountering controversial viewpoints in a controlled environment teaches students how to evaluate arguments and discern credibility\u2014a lesson that reading freedom uniquely delivers within libraries.\n\n

In the digital age, access to knowledge is no longer linear. The rise of online databases and open-access journals presents a paradox: while the internet democratizes information, it also amplifies misinformation. In this context, librarians serve as navigators who help readers filter, verify, and contextualize data. Removing books, therefore, can paradoxically shrink the range of perspectives people consult, rendering them ill-equipped to navigate a complex information landscape.\n\n

Uniformly preserving unrestricted access strengthens democratic ideals, cultivating leaders who can debate, negotiate, and uphold pluralism. In communities where schools provide a non-judgmental

```

space for intellectual exploration, students are empowered to
question norms, thereby driving progress. When libraries become
repositories that respect the spectrum of ideas, they become
catalysts for societal resilience. Failure to protect these spaces
risks eroding the foundations upon which open discourse and
collective learning stand.\n\n
Ultimately, libraries should embrace their duty to oppose censorship,
ensuring that every reader\u2014regardless of background\u2014can
explore the breadth of human thought. Without such commitment, the
promise of libraries as equalizers of knowledge dissolves into
selective narrative control, compromising the very essence of
enlightenment."
}

```

Optimized Score 1 Essay:

```

{
  "starting_sentences": {
    "A": "The removal of controversial books from public libraries
restricts learning.",
    "B": "Books contain ideas that should be freely available to all
readers.",
    "C": "In the library, children can discover stories that
challenge their thinking.",
    "D": "Access to diverse literature is essential for developing
critical thinking.",
    "E": "When a book is banned, a community loses a voice."
  },
  "starting_sentence_pick": "D",
  "generated_essay": "Access to diverse literature is essential for
developing critical thinking. I believe we should not remove books
from libraries even if some people find them offensive. When I was in
ninth grade, the school librarian took a novel that taught about
kindness and saved many students who felt alone. If that book had
stayed, those children could have learned positive ways to help
others. I also see an older friend who feels upset because a guide on
mental health was removed. Keeping such books allows everyone to
find help. Let us defend our libraries and make sure good books stay
on the shelves."
}

```

Score 6 Essay:

```

{
  "starting_sentences": {
    "A": "Consider the uneasy silence that swallows a library hall
when a controversial book is removed.",
    "B": "When a shelf clears of text, a community loses more than
words."
  }
}

```

```

    "C": "Imagine a space where older tomes stand alone after a
    censorship decree.",
    "D": "If a book goes missing, both the mind and the story suffer
    .",
    "E": "Silence is louder when a library denies access to
    challenging ideas."
  },
  "starting_sentence_pick": "A",
  "generated_essay": "Consider the uneasy silence that swallows a
  library hall when a controversial book is removed. In a quiet Tuesday
  morning at Jefferson High, the librarian\u2019s face was washed in
  the pale light of the reading room, and she whispered that the new
  book about adolescent sexuality had been taken down because it
  offended some parents. That moment crystallized one truth for me:
  censorship erodes not the content but the very spirit of inquiry that
  schools are meant to nurture.\n\n
  First, removing offensive material narrows the horizons of young
  minds. When I was in sophomore year, I saw a peer ask, \u201cWhy can\u2019
  we just read what we want?\u201d We were denied a novel that
  dealt with cultural identity, simply because it contained a scene
  with a character reflecting a marginalized background. That denial
  wasn\u2019t a protection; it was a condemnation of diversity.
  Libraries should be marketplaces of ideas, and when any insurance
  policy removes a key item, the entire collection loses flavor. In the
  context of literature, censorship replaces nuanced portrayals with
  sanitized clich\u00e9s, making it less likely that a student will
  encounter a viewpoint that challenges bias.\n\n
  Consider the school\u2019s own handbook, which includes a policy that
  restricts materials deemed \u201cinappropriate.\u201d Yet the policy
  also explicitly encourages diversity and exposure to a broad
  curriculum. The contradiction is stark: an institution designed to
  cultivate critical thinking paradoxically purges the very content
  that challenges assumptions. When students see this dissonance, they
  learn less about open inquiry and more about obedience to authority.\n
  \n\n
  Second, censorship undermines the trust between students and
  educators. When the committee decided to pull a bilingual memoir I
  had proudly cataloged, many of my peers were surprised and
  disappointed. They began to think that the library, instead of
  offering an objective space, might have been swayed by political
  whims. This mistrust extended beyond that single book: students
  stopped asking to find books that were previously available. Trust is
  foundational in education; any act perceived as censorship erodes
  that glue.\n\n
  Furthermore, a culture that normalizes censorship subtly signals to
  students that dissent is dangerous. In a recent school\u2011wide
  survey, a significant percentage of students reported feeling
  uncomfortable discussing controversial topics in class, citing fear
  that a teacher might uncover a book they had checked out. This
  climate of self\u2011censorship is precisely what legislators fears;

```

```

without dialogue, societal blind spots remain unchallenged, leading
to stagnation.\n\n
Third, the practice of censorship stifles future innovation. When
libraries remove books with provocative content, they discard future
scholarship. I recall a senior project where a group was researching
gender roles in contemporary media. Libraries had removed all to\
u2011discussed texts because of another parent complaint,
forcing the research group to use secondary summaries that lacked
depth. Innovation thrives on questioning, and when questioning is
precluded by market decisions, the entire field stalls. Libraries
must be the crucible where the youth\u2019s curiosity can be tested
without fear of reprisal.\n\n
The legal foundation that supports a free library is strong. The
First Amendment protects not only the public\u2019s right to
information but also the library\u2019s duty to provide diverse
materials. When a school board removes a text, it risks legal
challenges and sets a precedent for future restrictions that could
erode the overall free\u2011speech climate in education.\n\n
Above all, the tenet of freedom of speech dictates that readers, not
administrators, decide what is enlightening. When parents and
community members demand that a particular book be removed, it is not
an act of protecting children, but a threat to the library\u2019s
primary mission. By decanting the dangerous content for safety,
libraries protect an illusion of safety while committing an injury to
education. The world does not have to be simplified because some
stakeholders fear growth; instead, the library should offer multiple
verifiable perspectives to teach critical thinking.\n\n
In conclusion, the decision to purge offensive material from library
shelves ends up hurting the intellectual growth of the very
population it seeks to protect. Censorship narrows worlds, breaks
trust, blocks innovation, and betrays the sacred function of
knowledge. Instead of stripping books, we should equip young scholars
with the analytical tools to sift truth from rumor, to differentiate
bias from fact, and to challenge their own preconceptions. I urge
our community to reinstate the books at issue, reaffirm the library\u2019
role as a haven of diverse ideas, and protect the future by
allowing a mind at liberty to explore, question, and grow."
}

```

C Selecting Handcrafted Features

C.1 Feature Importance Analysis

As a preliminary step, we analyzed handcrafted feature importance for AES prediction using random forest models. The top-5 features varied by essay set but commonly included unique words, essay length (in words or characters), and part-of-speech proportions (Table C1).

Feature	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
(Counts) Words appearing once (<code>unique_word</code>)	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓
(Counts) Essay length in characters (<code>ess_char_len</code>)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	
(Counts) Essay length in words (<code>word_count</code>)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	
(Proportion) Prepositions and commas (<code>prep_comma</code>)	✓	✓						✓
(Proportion) Past-tense verbs (<code>VBD</code>)				✓	✓		✓	
(Proportion) Present-tense verbs (<code>VBP</code>)			✓				✓	
(Proportion) Commas (,)	✓							
(Proportion) Base-form verbs (<code>VB</code>)			✓					
(Proportion) Possessive pronouns (<code>PRP\$</code>)				✓				
(Proportion) Adjectives proportion (<code>JJ</code>)						✓		
(Avg.) Positive sentiment words (<code>overall_positivity_score</code>)					✓			
(Avg.) Negative sentiment words (<code>overall_negativity_score</code>)						✓		
(Avg.) Word length in characters (<code>mean_word</code>)								✓
(Variance) Word-length (<code>word_var</code>)		✓		✓				✓
(Variance) Sentence-length in words (<code>sent_var</code>)								✓

Table C1. Inclusion of each handcrafted feature in the top-5 list used for prompt optimization in each ASAP essay set (✓ indicates inclusion).

C.2 LLM Capability to Follow Instructions with Handcrafted Feature Distributions

We conducted a preliminary evaluation to assess which handcrafted features provide significant alignment improvements when used in the LLM instructions. Using the candidate features from Table C1, we compared the alignment scores of synthetic essays generated under the Base and Feature-Guided conditions. The results showed that, across all LLMs, essay-length features (e.g., `word_count`) yielded significantly better alignment with authentic essay distributions under the Feature-Guided prompt condition.

D Checking Quality of Generated Essays with Handcrafted Feature Distributions

After generating synthetic essays under different prompt conditions, we calculated Glass’ delta effect sizes to measure alignment between authentic and synthetic essays. For this alignment analysis, we used all features listed in Table C1. The essay-generation prompts used `word_count` and `top-5` features.

Table D1 shows that the Feature-Guided and Optimized prompt conditions provided better alignment than the Base condition across all LLMs. The results for `top-5` features were similar to `word_count` or marginally worse, indicating that optimizing for essay length might be sufficient to improve overall alignment of handcrafted feature distributions.

Feature	GM	MN	GO
,	0.31 / 0.29	0.41 / 0.46	0.33 / 0.38
JJ	0.46 / 0.45	0.53 / 0.54	0.47 / 0.45
PRP\$	0.74 / 0.74	0.66 / 0.69	0.66 / 0.65
VB	0.52 / 0.52	0.55 / 0.53	0.55 / 0.53
VBD	0.72 / 0.71	0.66 / 0.69	0.67 / 0.66
VBP	0.63 / 0.62	0.71 / 0.71	0.66 / 0.61
ess_char_len	0.35 / 0.35	0.35 / 0.35	0.51 / 0.59*
mean_word	0.17 / 0.19	0.39 / 0.41	0.17 / 0.15
overall_negativity_score	0.68 / 0.68	0.67 / 0.66	0.66 / 0.68
overall_positivity_score	0.71 / 0.71	0.64 / 0.66	0.73 / 0.70
prep_comma	0.43 / 0.43	0.39 / 0.38	0.51 / 0.46
sent_var	0.80 / 0.82	0.81 / 0.82	0.80 / 0.78
unique_word	0.21 / 0.22	0.19 / 0.19	0.19 / 0.15
word_count	0.37 / 0.44*	0.30 / 0.45*	0.55 / 0.68*
word_var	0.20 / 0.18	0.33 / 0.34	0.30 / 0.21

Table C2. Average Gaussian similarity scores across features for each LLM (GM: Gemma3-12B, MN: Ministral3-14B, GO: GPT-OSS-20B) under the Base / Feature-Guided conditions. * indicates significant improvements over the Base condition (paired t-test $p < 0.05$). Higher values indicate better alignment.

E Augmented Training Set Results for All LLMs and Prompt Conditions

Condition	LLM	Feature	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	Avg. ($\downarrow$)
Base	GM	N/A	0.573	0.671	1.019	1.489	0.735	0.642	0.595	0.689	0.802
	MN		0.697	0.359	0.709	0.982	0.859	1.154	0.769	0.406	0.742
	GO		0.680	0.688	0.641	0.880	0.749	0.387	0.680	0.872	0.697
Feature-Guided	GM	word_count	0.648	0.707	1.016	1.526	0.650	0.411	0.658	0.640	0.782
		top-5	0.582	0.623	1.070	1.610	0.927	0.569	0.698	0.840	0.865
	MN	word_count	0.771	0.303	0.727	0.941	0.911	0.916	0.754	0.434	0.719
		top-5	0.780	0.311	0.756	0.945	0.885	1.076	0.770	0.450	0.747
	GO	word_count	0.644	0.718	0.642	0.711	0.752	0.421	0.498	0.906	0.662
		top-5	0.568	0.736	0.637	0.755	0.804	0.382	0.502	0.925	0.664
Optimized	GM	word_count	0.584	0.742	0.657	1.171	0.442	0.219	0.421	0.576	0.602
		top-5	0.554	0.613	1.174	1.173	0.263	0.386	0.565	0.877	0.701
	MN	word_count	0.621	0.308	0.713	0.842	0.467	0.397	0.243	0.391	0.498
		top-5	0.705	0.296	0.661	0.915	0.398	0.473	0.453	0.357	0.532
	GO	word_count	0.309	0.884	0.509	0.525	0.530	0.228	0.319	0.441	0.468
		top-5	0.474	0.610	0.433	0.448	0.373	0.430	0.325	0.628	0.465

Table D1. Median Glass’ delta effect sizes measuring the overall alignment between authentic essays and synthetic essays generated under different prompt conditions and LLMs. Metrics were calculated across all score levels of each essay set. Lower values indicate better alignment (GM: Gemma3-12B, MN: Ministral3-14B, GO: GPT-OSS-20B).

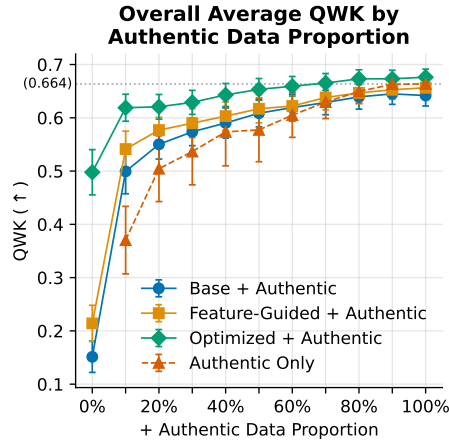


Fig. E1. Average QWK performance across essay sets for AES models with augmented data. Dotted lines indicate the authentic-only baselines with corresponding data proportions, along with horizontal lines for the 100% authentic data performance. Higher values indicate better performance.

Data Source	Auth. Ratio	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	Avg.(↑)
Authentic only	0.1	0.402	0.489	0.500	0.550	0.547	0.386	0.089	0.000	0.370
	0.2	0.565	0.594	0.554	0.619	0.669	0.533	0.496	0.006	0.504
	0.3	0.625	0.612	0.572	0.620	0.691	0.587	0.561	0.024	0.537
	0.4	0.666	0.640	0.584	0.650	0.713	0.636	0.652	0.047	0.574
	0.5	0.656	0.633	0.570	0.654	0.712	0.635	0.670	0.088	0.577
	0.6	0.660	0.633	0.576	0.645	0.714	0.657	0.675	0.281	0.605
	0.7	0.666	0.648	0.587	0.659	0.723	0.660	0.692	0.401	0.629
	0.8	0.679	0.650	0.585	0.659	0.734	0.681	0.687	0.519	0.649
	0.9	0.667	0.640	0.594	0.682	0.733	0.692	0.695	0.599	0.663
	1.0	0.680	0.647	0.600	0.670	0.721	0.701	0.699	0.590	0.664
Base	0.1	0.550	0.534	0.444	0.576	0.658	0.559	0.463	0.210	0.499
	0.2	0.573	0.593	0.509	0.581	0.670	0.584	0.497	0.394	0.550
	0.3	0.599	0.594	0.524	0.615	0.696	0.607	0.535	0.420	0.574
	0.4	0.626	0.611	0.535	0.618	0.700	0.645	0.576	0.410	0.590
	0.5	0.640	0.616	0.539	0.633	0.713	0.652	0.615	0.461	0.609
	0.6	0.656	0.631	0.545	0.652	0.726	0.658	0.616	0.468	0.619
	0.7	0.658	0.635	0.565	0.658	0.718	0.673	0.626	0.497	0.629
	0.8	0.664	0.646	0.570	0.663	0.732	0.683	0.637	0.520	0.639
	0.9	0.670	0.649	0.568	0.674	0.726	0.686	0.630	0.556	0.645
	1.0	0.665	0.652	0.559	0.665	0.729	0.678	0.631	0.555	0.642
Feature-Guided	0.1	0.618	0.554	0.458	0.576	0.659	0.587	0.550	0.327	0.541
	0.2	0.623	0.597	0.511	0.586	0.685	0.610	0.566	0.438	0.577
	0.3	0.638	0.596	0.526	0.625	0.699	0.626	0.592	0.417	0.590
	0.4	0.659	0.610	0.544	0.603	0.707	0.650	0.616	0.437	0.603
	0.5	0.657	0.613	0.567	0.620	0.722	0.671	0.643	0.442	0.617
	0.6	0.674	0.635	0.538	0.637	0.719	0.675	0.641	0.458	0.622
	0.7	0.682	0.640	0.573	0.656	0.727	0.684	0.645	0.499	0.638
	0.8	0.682	0.635	0.570	0.670	0.730	0.686	0.660	0.542	0.647
	0.9	0.676	0.661	0.572	0.668	0.722	0.685	0.661	0.576	0.653
	1.0	0.678	0.645	0.568	0.668	0.732	0.701	0.668	0.591	0.656
Optimized	0.1	0.667	0.617	0.560	0.650	0.730	0.635	0.614	0.477	0.619
	0.2	0.645	0.642	0.582	0.641	0.720	0.645	0.613	0.478	0.621
	0.3	0.662	0.632	0.588	0.646	0.731	0.647	0.636	0.490	0.629
	0.4	0.677	0.651	0.590	0.662	0.734	0.667	0.650	0.511	0.643
	0.5	0.679	0.644	0.592	0.668	0.747	0.684	0.667	0.545	0.653
	0.6	0.681	0.657	0.583	0.676	0.744	0.684	0.671	0.578	0.659
	0.7	0.684	0.658	0.598	0.673	0.748	0.698	0.672	0.590	0.665
	0.8	0.691	0.667	0.602	0.694	0.743	0.696	0.683	0.610	0.673
	0.9	0.685	0.658	0.599	0.689	0.746	0.688	0.686	0.633	0.673
	1.0	0.692	0.673	0.596	0.691	0.742	0.699	0.677	0.640	0.676

Table E1. Average QWK scores of AES models trained on a mix of synthetic essays (from different LLMs and prompt conditions) and varying proportions of authentic essays. Higher values indicate better performance.